
GRANT WOODS

DEER HUNTING METHODOLOGY

Mindset · Habitat · Pressure · Routes · Thermals · Bottlenecks

A detailed compilation of how wildlife biologist Dr. Grant R. Woods thinks about white-tailed deer — food, cover, water, and security; destination plots versus hidey-holes; hunting pressure defined as alerting deer; approach / hunt / exit; threading the needle; and the property-design loop he runs on GrowingDeer.tv.

THE SIX-STEP OPERATING SYSTEM

1. Name the scarcest neighborhood resource — then build it better than the neighbors.
2. Pair food, cover, water, and a true sanctuary so deer feel safe on your acres.
3. Design bottlenecks (natural and built) so daylight travel is predictable.
4. Hang nothing until approach, hunt, and exit can be done without alerting a deer.
5. Hunt the wind and the thermal. If either is wrong, stay out.
6. Keep enough wind-specific stands that you never have to cheat a sit.

Prepared for Casey Summerlin · Anson County, North Carolina
September 9, 2026

*Drawn from GrowingDeer.tv, public seminars, interviews, and published writing.
Not a substitute for Dr. Woods' own show, consulting, or a paid habitat plan.*

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This document is a field study, not a reprint of GrowingDeer episodes and not a how-to for illegal activity. Tactics are compiled from material Dr. Woods has published or spoken about publicly. Habitat and harvest decisions must follow North Carolina Wildlife Resources Commission rules.

1. Who Grant Woods Is — and Why His System Matters

Grant R. Woods (born June 11, 1961) is an American wildlife biologist specializing in free-ranging, hunted white-tailed deer and the habitat that grows them. He was raised on a small farm at the edge of the Missouri Ozarks at a time when deer were still scarce in his county. Finding a poached fawn as a boy is the origin story he still tells: he wanted to understand deer, then work with them for a living.

Education is part of why hunters listen. B.S. in Zoology / Computer Information Systems and an M.S. in zoology from Southwest Missouri State (now Missouri State); doctoral work that began at the University of Georgia under R. Larry Marchinton and finished as a Ph.D. in Forest Resources at Clemson in 1994. His dissertation studied traditional rubs and the human dimensions of quality deer management. He has run Woods & Associates as a research-and-consulting shop since 1990, was a founding partner of BioLogic (1998–2005), and has spent decades designing site-specific plans for private land.

The public face is GrowingDeer.tv, launched so he could put current hunt-and-habitat work in front of people every week. A new episode drops each Monday, 52 weeks a year, with no repeats. The original classroom was The Proving Grounds — a worn-out Ozark cattle ranch of about 1,500 acres that he and his wife Tracy bought around 2001–2002 and rebuilt with invasive control, fire, native plants, timber work, and food plots. That property later sold; he has continued the same loop on newer ground. He has been part of the Bass Pro / RedHead Pro Hunting Team, and the Missouri Department of Conservation has recognized him as a Master Conservationist (2019) with later conservation honors.

HuntBrief uses Woods as the habitat-and-pressure layer on top of Brad Herndon's terrain engine. Herndon tells you where a buck's feet will go. Woods tells you how to build the grocery, the bedroom, and the quiet path so those feet move in daylight — and how to sit there without writing your name on the air.

2. The Core Mindset

The biggest problem with hunters is that they think like humans. To be a successful hunter, you have to think like a deer.

— Grant Woods

Woods is a biologist who also kills mature bucks. He does not hunt “spots” in the magazine sense. He designs a property so deer have to move through predictable places in daylight, then he only sits when wind, thermals, and access let him do it without the deer ever knowing he was there.

Six beliefs he actually hunts by

- **Four needs, every day.** Food, cover, water, and security. Cover is structure. Security is structure that is not threatened.
- **Pressure is alerting, not occupancy.** A hundred clean sits is zero pressure. Three sloppy sits can nocturnalize a spot for weeks.
- **The hunter is a predator.** Habitat work is how you make a deer drop his guard. Attract him, give him a safe room, hunt the hallway — not the mattress.
- **The neighborhood beats the fence line.** You cannot out-feed three sides of commercial soybeans. You can intercept the travel to those beans.
- **Access is half the stand.** A great tree with a dirty walk is a bad stand. Approach, hunt, and exit are one decision.
- **Thermals over the forecast arrow.** Deer live on micro-currents. Hunters stare at the big wind barb and miss the ravine that is draining scent at daylight.

He is also impatient with magic. He has publicly downplayed moon tables as a primary driver. He wants biology you can see: browse height, coat condition, which forage is green this week, which slope is holding the cool air, which path lets a buck keep cover between food and bed.

3. The Four Daily Needs: Food, Cover, Water, Security

Food

Quality forage is usually the limiting piece during deer season in the places he works. He wants high-quality food available in the two crunch periods — late summer and late winter — not just a pretty October plot. Blends beat monocultures because weather is variable. Soil test first. Forage soybeans in the warm season, then a diverse cool-season mix (the Buffalo / Fall Buffalo idea: replicate how prairie soils were built, not just plant a strip of wheat) is the pattern he has taught for years.

He monitors the herd by walking browse, not by running a camera census. If preferred browse is short or hammered in late summer and again in late winter, there are more mouths than groceries. The deer cannot express their genetic potential. Density slogans interest him less than that simple forage test.

Cover

Cover is where wildlife goes to avoid danger. It does not have to look like a wall of saplings. Deer feed on golf courses in daylight because they have learned they are rarely threatened there. Structure plus low threat equals usable cover. Native grass, cedar cuts, young timber, and screened edges all count if the deer believe they will not be jumped.

Water

He likes small, quiet water — something on the order of two pickup trucks, not a roaring river that masks predator sound. Livestock should be fenced off it. A pond dam with an easy-side approach is also a stand: deer take the walkable grade, and that grade is a pinch.

Security — the fourth need he added

This is the word most hunters skip. Thick vegetation that you walk every weekend is cover. The same thicket that nobody enters from September through January is security. Mature bucks age into that distinction. Woods designs sanctuaries so a buck has a room on the

property where he believes he will not be seen. Deer that feel secure are less alert on the rest of the farm — which is why sanctuaries make the huntable acres easier, not wasted.

4. Property Design — Hunt the Neighborhood First

Before he walks a client's gate he opens OnX and studies the neighborhood. Where are the big ag fields? Where is the cover on the adjoining tracts? What is scarce within a home-range of the fence?

First job: provide the resource that is least available next door. That is the fastest way to pull and hold wildlife. Second job: build the other two (or three) needs better than the surroundings so deer can complete a daily loop without leaving. Over time that loop produces more animals and, if age structure is protected, more mature bucks.

On a farm boxed in by commercial soybeans he will not try to out-feed the farmer with giant destination plots. He will put staging / hidey-hole plots on the travel path to those beans, thicken cover, and lock down sanctuaries so the deer linger on your acres in daylight. The beans still feed the herd. Your dirt hunts the commute.

He is blunt about year-round presence. The worst pattern he sees on client land: the property sits quiet all summer, then opening week every truck drives every trail. A UTV that uses the same interior road all year and never stops in cover becomes furniture. A truck that appears only in November is a coyote.

5. Destination Plots, Hidey-Holes, and Built Bottlenecks

Two plots, two jobs

Destination / feeding plots are larger and built to grow the herd and hold deer. Forage soybeans in summer, a diverse cool-season blend in fall. You often do *not* sit the middle of them. You sit the ditch that cuts them, the hardwood strip that feeds them, the corner that dumps a creek into them.

Hidey-hole / staging plots are tiny — sometimes a fraction of an acre — tucked in cover on the way to the big food. Deer stop there in daylight before they commit to the open field after dark. These are kill plots. They are also artificial bottlenecks: a closed-canopy woods with one green grocery in the middle forces travel to a point you can cover with a bow.

Shape is a hunting decision

He does not draw big squares because the tractor likes squares. He draws long and skinny. He leaves a hardwood travel strip. He uses a ravine that already crosses the opening. He stops a skinny plot about 70 yards short of a creek and 70 yards short of a destination field so deer must commit at one end or the other — and both ends get a stand. Crabapple at the Proving Grounds is the teaching example: food, plus a ditch, plus scrapes, plus two blinds so a north wind and a south/west wind are both live.

Screens matter. A plot visible from the county road is a rumor the neighbors will hunt. Hide the grocery. Put the stand where you can thread scent off the travel path, not across the plot you just built.

Invisible bottlenecks

His favorite set pieces do not look like a fence. Topography plus a small plot plus a pond dam plus an old logging road that already crossed the ridge at the only walkable grade. Nothing is a hard edge. Everything dumps deer to 15–20 yards. He will also hunt the bench — the mid-slope flat with steep above and steep below — because deer already use it as the easy grade. Then he adds food or a screen so the bench becomes a stand instead of a rumor.

6. Sanctuaries and Timber Work

To benefit the deer herd where you hunt, don't just think about ways to attract them and make the deer easier to see, but think about managing enough of the habitat to insure each deer has a place where they believe they won't be seen.

— Grant Woods

Sanctuaries are the cheapest cover you can make. You just stay out. He puts them on the Proving Grounds and on client maps. Deer adopt them quickly if there is not another quiet block in the home range. Movement on the rest of the farm becomes readable: leave the sanctuary, stage, feed, return.

A common layout when the main food is already in the center of the farm: sanctuaries on the outside corners, hidey-hole plots between the sanctuary and the destination field. The hunter slides into the staging plot on the correct wind and catches the mature buck that will not step into the big field until dark.

Pie-and-slice timber

Closed-canopy hardwoods are a food desert and a hunt mess — deer wander. Woods treats a timber block like a pie and cuts odd-numbered slices on a rotation so you always have young, medium, and old age classes in the same neighborhood. Young cuts give browse, fawning cover, and hard edges. Older slices keep mast. Edges create pinch points. Pinch points become stands. Hack-and-squirt TSI on low-value stems (striped maple, sassafras, crowded midstory) lets oak crowns and native forage respond without a full logging job.

Invasives come off first — lespedeza, multiflora rose, knapweed, and the other passengers that steal the understory. Prescribed fire, where legal and appropriate, is a regular tool for native grass and forbs. He is not romantic about it. Habitat is a multi-year loop, not a Saturday project.

7. Hunting Pressure, Defined His Way

Hunting pressure is when you alert deer or they know you're there. You can hunt a stand 100 days in a row and if they don't know you're there, it's a zero to them.

— Grant Woods

This is the sentence that separates Woods from the “I hunted it twice, I have to move” crowd. Occupancy is not pressure. Detection is pressure. A deer that smelled you 200 yards back in thick timber may never give you the courtesy of a blow. He just curled around you. You log a blank sit. He logs a predator.

Implications he actually hunts by:

- Do not abandon a good tree because you sat it. Abandon it because you burned it.
- You often do not know when you alerted them. Plan as if you did.
- Walking a half mile through bedding to “get away from the road” can put more scent on the ground than a known UTV on a known interior road.
- On private land with an interior road network, short walks from a drop-off beat heroic hikes.
- On public land the opposite can be true — other hunters already pressure the road edge, so the extra walk can be the advantage.
- If the habitat is excellent but the place is hunted sloppy, mature deer go nocturnal. Fix the hunting before you plant another acre.

He wants multiple hunters to have multiple wind options so nobody is forced into a dirty sit just to “get out there.” A property with ten honest places and four winds covered will outhunt a property with two hero trees that only work twice a fall.

8. Routes, Paths, and Access

I only have one rule about placing stands and blinds: the hunter must be able to approach, hunt, and exit without alerting deer.

— Grant Woods

The path is not a footnote to the stand. The path *is* the stand. He will not hang a tree until the walk is solved for the time of day the sit will actually happen — morning thermals are not afternoon thermals.

How he wants you to move

- **Vehicle first.** Get as close as you can. Ideal is stepping off a UTV onto the stand. The engine that deer already know is less of a threat than a sweating human laying a mile of scent.
- **Never through the plot, never through the bed.** If the walk crosses the food or the sanctuary, the sit is already over.
- **Perimeter paths.** On a west wind, go all the way to the east boundary, then cut in. Northwest wind: come from the south edge. Southwest: from the north. The walking path is as important as any habitat feature on the farm.
- **Ridge spines.** Walk the crest. A few feet off either side, deer below cannot see you. Only the deer already on the spine can.
- **Dry drains and ditches** when the wind allows — quiet, hidden, and often already the thermal sewer.
- **Exit is equal to entry.** Get picked up if you can. Do not walk out through the deer you just watched feed.
- **Interior roads next to stands** are an asset on private ground because they shrink the human footprint.

He will build those paths on purpose. Machete a silent fence-line walk. Keep a two-track that only serves stands. If the only way to a plot is across the plot, the plot is not hunt-able — it is a feeder.

9. Wind, Thermals, and Threading the Needle

Hunting the wind correctly is, in his words, a primary strategy for killing mature bucks — animals that reached that age by avoiding predators. But he thinks most hunters stop at the big forecast arrow and miss what the deer actually use.

Thermals are local weather

- Cold air is heavy. At first light it sinks downhill like water, down the ravine of least resistance.
- Warm air rises. Midday and evening thermals climb slopes.
- Dawn and dusk are when temperature — and therefore air — changes the most. That is also when deer move.
- Valleys swirl. Creek bottoms swirl. Sidehill plots swirl. He avoids them except on hard-cold mornings when the sink stays predictable until mid-morning.
- Ridgetops have stable wind. At the Proving Grounds they have said they kill the large majority of deer on ridgetops even though deer do not spend most of their lives there — because that is where a human can hunt clean.
- A north slope stays shaded longer. Morning thermals stay downhill longer. That is a stand feature, not trivia.

Practical sit rules

Morning: often one-half to three-quarters of the way *down* a shaded slope so sinking thermals carry scent into the draw, not up into the beds. Pre-rut and rut bucks also cruise low on the slope so doe scent drains to them. Afternoon: higher, or on the side where rising thermals do not blow into the approach or the bed. Light, warm, swirling days get shortened to the thermal windows — or he stays out. He likes a consistent wind around 7 mph or better for all-day sits.

Threading the needle

He prefers a **crosswind**, not a “perfect” downwind that also dumps scent into the bedding. The best sits feel a few degrees from getting busted: the scent stream runs just off the travel path, never into it. Mature bucks walk that line because they feel secure. He will set a stand so scent threads down a lake edge, a ditch, or dead space while deer use the hardwood runner a few yards away. That is the needle.

Scent-control soap (he has used enzyme systems rather than perfume cover) is hygiene. It is not a license to hunt a dirty wind. Wind plus access beat soap every time.

10. Stand Architecture — Where the Tree Actually Goes

He is hunting bottlenecks, not sign. Rub lines are notes in the margin. The sentence is the landform plus the resource plus the walk.

Natural pins

Saddles, benches, inside corners, creek funnels, pond dams, the easy side of a steep slope, the hardwood strip between two covers, a utility ROW pinch, the ditch through a plot. In flat country the pin is an edge: crop versus timber, pine versus hardwood, a water barrier, a downed fence. In the mountains the pin is grade: mid-slope benches, ridge spines, the only place a logging road could cross.

Built pins

A hidey-hole in closed timber. A long skinny plot that forces a commit at either end. Cedar-cut edges. A screen of timber left on purpose. Two blinds on opposite corners of the same destination plot so the area stays live when the wind flips. He wants a minimum of four honest places per hunter on a property — one family of sits for each major wind. Same plot, different corners, is allowed. Forcing the wrong tree is not.

Cameras stay off the stand tree

The camera is not what educates a mature buck. You walking in to hang it and check it is. Cams go on food, travel, and scrapes. Then he plots the pictures on a map. The map is the pattern. A camera roll is just a pile of antlers with timestamps.

Ground hunting is allowed if the wind stays in your favor and you time the arrival — for example, stalking into a feeding area ten minutes before dark instead of sitting through three hours of swirl. The direct route is rarely the right route. Check the wind constantly. If it dies or flips, leave.

11. Patterning a Mature Buck

Two strategies. He uses both. He prefers the second when you own or lease the same dirt every year.

Strategy A — hunt the feature. Sit the best travel or bedding pinch and let the right buck use it. This is how you hunt ground you do not know yet, or ground that gets new bucks every fall.

Strategy B — hunt the individual. Identify one mature buck. Plot his food–cover–water–security loop on a map. Find the weak link — the daylight pinch he must use. Hunt only that link, and only on the exact wind that keeps you invisible.

Trail cameras help if they are organized against the map. They tell you sex, age class, and time of day in a way tracks and browse cannot. They do not replace the four-needs sketch. A buck that lights up a destination plot at 10 p.m. is telling you to hunt the staging plot at 5:30 p.m., not to sit the same camera tree at dawn.

Passing young bucks is a management decision, not a morality play. A spoken “three-year-old goal” is really a four-year-old animal if you count the button-buck year. He has told hunters that averaging one mature buck per 100–200 acres per year is a strong result on ordinary landscapes. Do not invent a Boone-and-Crockett quota on 40 acres of average dirt.

Calling is a closer, not a plan. He has used a grunt (the Messenger) when a buck is already in the area and needs a reason to take the last twenty yards. The habitat and the wind did the heavy work.

12. The Seasonal Calendar

Early season

Pattern the food that is actually being eaten this week — standing beans, persimmons, early mast — not the food you wish they were on. Hunt the hidey-hole on the way to it. Coat and heat matter. If it is still hot and winter hair is coming, they bed shady north slopes and may not hit open food until dark. Sit the staging plot, not the field.

Pre-rut

His favorite window for mature bucks. Bucks cover ground in daylight looking for the first receptive does. Hunt travel between doe bedding and food. Bottlenecks and scrapes on those routes. He has said plainly that he prefers the pre-rut and the days just after peak breeding over lockdown itself.

Lockdown / peak rut

Bucks do not cruise as far. Sit where does live — bedding edges, not the destination field they will hit after dark. If you only watch a big plot during lockdown you will swear the rut is dead. The bucks are 200 yards back in the cover with a doe.

Post-rut / late season

Food again. Standing beans or a still-green blend. A more advanced trick he has written about: find the fawn groups. Late-season doe fawns keep a regular feeding schedule; mature bucks check them. After a heavy doe harvest, orphan groups bunch up and become a magnet. Hunt the grocery those fawns use, on a clean wind, after you have left it alone long enough that the deer are calm in daylight.

13. Herd Management, Browse, and Doe Harvest

Better food pulls the neighbors' deer. If you do not shoot enough does, you starve the plot and you grow a nocturnal herd. On well-fed ground he has used harvest goals on the order of several does per 100 acres when browse said the mouths were ahead of the groceries. The exact number is local. The trigger is the browse, not a magazine ratio.

Age structure is the antler factory. Let some bucks reach the body type he describes in the field: hump over the shoulders, chest sagging below the shoulders, neck merging with the brisket. Middle-aged bucks look straighter in the back and belly. Yearlings look like antlered does. Pass what your goal says to pass. Shoot the does the forage says you must.

He is not anti-production agriculture. He is anti-wasted hunting opportunity. A soybean program in summer can get you ahead of the herd. A fall blend is the hunting crop. Native browse and mast still have to work or the deer leave when the plot gets stale. Tree plots — nut and fruit trees inside or beside a forage plot — stagger attraction across the season.

14. The Six-Step Operating System

1. Name the scarce resource.

Study the neighborhood before you study your fence. Build the thing the deer cannot get next door.

2. Complete the daily loop on your acres.

Food, cover, water, and a sanctuary the deer believe is safe. If one piece lives across the line, they will finish the day over there.

3. Force daylight travel through pins.

Use terrain you already have. Add hidey-holes, skinny plots, screens, and timber edges so a bow range is not a coincidence.

4. Solve approach, hunt, and exit first.

Perimeter paths, ridge spines, short walks off known interior roads. No stand without a clean walk for the time of day you will sit it.

5. Hunt wind and thermal, or stay home.

Ridgetops for stable air. Mid-slope on cold mornings when scent drains to the draw. Crosswinds that thread the needle. Swirl days are off days.

6. Own every wind without cheating.

Four-plus honest sits per hunter. Two corners of the same plot count. Forcing a dirty tree so you can “get out there” is how you train mature deer to go night-only.

One-sentence version: build food, cover, water, and a place the deer believe is safe; hunt the pinch between those things; get there and leave without writing your name on the air; if the wind or the thermal is wrong, you do not go.

15. Woods vs. Herndon vs. Higgins vs. LaPratt

HuntBrief already carries field studies on Brad Herndon, Don Higgins, and Tony LaPratt. Woods does not replace them. He occupies a different chair at the same table.

Brad Herndon is the terrain engine. Points, saddles, benches, inside corners, creek funnels, hilltop field funnels, converging hubs, breaklines. Map first. Path of least resistance that stays in cover. Wind as the first filter. Woods agrees with all of it, then adds resources and pressure on top of the same map: put a staging plot on that point, a sanctuary behind it, a road that lets you walk in from the downwind edge, and two stands so the point is live on a north *and* a west wind.

Don Higgins is the low-pressure pole. True sanctuary, hunt only the fringe, design the farm around pre-chosen stand winds, temperature and fronts as movement triggers, same-time / same-place annual patterns, and the discipline to stay home. Woods is less “never go inside” and more “go inside only on a clean route, and have so many wind options you never have to cheat.” Both men obsess over alerting deer. They draw the keep-out line in different places.

Tony LaPratt is architecture and mock-scrape / edge design in the Michigan-and-beyond style — build the farm so the buck walks a script. Woods will build pins too, but he starts from biology (what is scarce, what the browse says, where thermals run) rather than from a single signature tactic.

Short hand for the Anson farm: Herndon says where the feet go. Woods says how to feed, hide, and approach those feet. Higgins says when to cash the sit and when to leave the tree unhunted. Use all three.

16. Applying This Thinking on the Anson County Farm

Locked facts for this property: Anson County, North Carolina, Central Deer Zone; 35.076243, -80.193882; 308.44 acres; large AG fields locked as soybeans for 2026; blue circles mark fall food plots; orange pins mark the named stands. Official stand list: Pine Thicket Stand, Braswell Back, Braswell Midway, Papa Bob Stand, GaGa Woods Stand, Upper Food Plot, Lower Food Plot, Upper Creeks Stand, Martys Stand, Papa Darin Stand, Drews Stand, Bottom Creek Stand, Papa Bobs Hill.

What Woods would do with that map

- **Treat the soybean fields as destination food** you often do not sit in the open. The herd is already grocery-shopping there. Hunt the commute.
- **Treat the fall food plots as hidey-holes / staging** wherever they sit on travel between bedding (creek bottoms, pine thickets, GaGa / Braswell woods) and those beans.
- **Lock at least one true sanctuary block** — a creek-bottom or pine thicket you stop walking “just to look.” Security is the scarce piece on a farm that already has beans.
- **Write an entry path and an exit path for every named stand**, tied to a wind family. If Pine Thicket only works on a west wind, another tree covers the opposite wind. Do not force it.
- **Prefer ridge and field-edge stands for stable wind.** Creek stands (Upper Creeks, Bottom Creek) are cold-morning thermal sits, not all-day sits.
- **Build perimeter / interior travel** so nobody cuts a soybean edge or a plot to reach Papa Bob, Upper Food Plot, or Bottom Creek.
- **Do harvest on purpose.** Those beans will pull deer. If browse on the plots and creek edges is short in late summer or late winter, you are over stocked for the forage you have.
- **Cameras on food and funnels, not on the stand tree.** Plot the photos on the same map as the stands.
- **Two corners on the best plots.** Upper and Lower Food Plot, and any fall plot that is already a daylight stop, should be hunt-able on more than one wind without walking the plot.

Early archery (open September 12, 2026 in the Central Zone) is a staging-plot season on this farm. Beans are still a destination. Days are warm. Thermals are sharp at first light and last light. The Woods sit is the hidey-hole on the downwind edge of travel, reached from a perimeter path, abandoned if the morning drain reverses before the buck moves.

17. Sources and How to Go Deeper

Primary source is GrowingDeer.tv — weekly field episodes, the “Thoughts from the Field” blog, and the Ask Grant answers. Property-design episodes (Georgia and Wisconsin walk-throughs, the 40-acre plans, the Crabapple hunts, “How to Get to Your Stand Without Getting Busted,” thermal breakdowns, pie-and-slice timber, sanctuary Q&As) are the working manuals. OutdoorHub's “How to Pattern Mature Bucks” and the Land.com maximizing-property interview collect the same ideas in prose. Bass Pro / RedHead profiles and his curriculum vitae confirm the research background (rubs, scrapes, quality deer management, human dimensions).

This field study is a synthesis for HuntBrief, prepared for Casey Summerlin on the Anson County farm. It is not a transcript of any episode, not a substitute for Dr. Woods' own words, and not a paid habitat plan. Where his public teaching has evolved (camera surveys versus browse checks, plot systems, which property he is currently running), trust the current GrowingDeer episode over any frozen summary — including this one.

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Field Card — Woods in one sit

Before you walk to a named stand on the Anson farm, run his checklist out loud. If any line fails, pick another tree or stay in the truck.

- What scarce resource am I hunting today — beans, a fall plot, mast, cover, or a sanctuary edge?
- Can I approach, hunt, and leave without crossing a plot, a bed, or a thermal sewer that dumps into deer?
- Is this a destination sit or a hidey-hole sit? Destination fields after dark are not the hunt.
- Does the forecast wind *and* the morning/evening thermal agree with this tree?
- Am I threading the needle (crosswind off the trail) or cheating scent into the bedroom?
- If I blank this sit, did I alert them — or did I just fail to see them? Only the first one burns the stand.